

THE ROSTER 2: FEED WAR

TSU Film 3 — the "Iron Man 2" release slot

THE PITCH

Platform: THE ROSTER, again — now dramatizing the Continuity Bible's locked Phase 1 Finale anchor event, **"The Feed War" (2004–2005): THE ROSTER absorbs/outlasts TOP8, TSU's first platform-vs-platform casualty event** (TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §3). This film covers the war's opening act — TOP8 mortally wounded, not yet finished — leaving the knockout blow for a true ensemble finale later in Phase 1's slate (per house style, a "standard platform-origin film" runtime/page count applies here, not the "Phase finale" spec; the full Avengers-style crossover event is reserved for a later film).

Why a second ROSTER film fits the Iron Man 2 slot exactly: Iron Man 2 is about the cost of being publicly, famously powerful — government pressure, copycat rivals, a legacy you didn't ask to inherit, and a hero quietly falling apart behind the confidence. THE ROSTER is now the most dominant platform in the industry, Marc-Anthony Bullock is famous in a way he wasn't in Film 1, and he did it by burning the one relationship built to keep him honest. That's a worse position than Tony Stark's, not a better one.

Who this film belongs to: Marc-Anthony Bullock, alone at the center in a way that's the whole point. Amond Baker does **not** appear onscreen — this film sits chronologically inside the same stretch where he's isolating in Atlanta at the start of `scripts/THE_WIRE.md`, and his absence is a wound this film keeps pressing on rather than one it resolves. Tyrese Avery steps into the "Rhodey" position — the friend who has to physically show up and run interference when Marc-Anthony can't. Esther Smilley steps into the "Pepper Potts" position — increasingly load-bearing on the business side, worried, still just a friend per the locked romantic timeline. Priya Ramasubramanian gets an expanded role, closing the film on a franchise-building tease.

In-universe timeline: April 2004 – January 2005. Opens two months after THE ROSTER's Feb 4, 2004 launch and closes around Marc-Anthony's 23rd birthday (Jan 5, 2005) — a deliberate bookend against Film 1, which opened on his 22nd. Ages verified against `TSU_Core_Cast.md`: Marc-Anthony 22 turning 23; Esther 21 turning 22 (Sept 20, 1982); Tyrese 22 turning 23 (July 24, 1981); Harmony 21 turning 22 (June 19, 1982); Arianna 21 turning 22 (Oct 25, 1982); Tyler 22 turning 23 (Jan 4, 1982, the day before Marc-Anthony as always). This window runs concurrent with the opening of `scripts/THE_WIRE.md` (which begins March 2005) — meaning Amond is already gone and isolating during this entire film, not yet building anything of his own.

LOGLINE

Ten months after the launch that made him, Marc-Anthony Bullock is the most powerful twenty-two-year-old in the industry and the loneliest man in every room he walks into. A rival platform's dying leadership, a vengeful engineer with a grudge older than he is, and a money man who wants to own what he can't build all come for THE ROSTER at once — and the only person who could usually talk

him off the ledge is the one person he's not allowed to call.

SYNOPSIS

THE ROSTER is winning, badly, in the specific way that makes winning look like violence: verified members flooding in, TOP8's engagement numbers visibly bleeding out week over week, headlines calling it "the fastest death of an internet empire anyone's ever watched happen in real time."

Marc-Anthony is everywhere — magazine covers, keynote stages, a documentary crew following him around that he agreed to in a moment he can no longer remember agreeing to. He has not spoken to Amond Baker in five months. He has also, quietly, started fainting.

He tells no one. Not Esther Smiley, who's been running half the company's actual operations from the inside while he does the talking-head circuit and won't say so out loud because she doesn't want to embarrass him. Not Tyrese Avery, who flies in from tour stops with increasing frequency for reasons he frames as "just checking in" and are actually closer to a welfare check. A cardiologist uses the word "arrhythmia" and the word "stress" in the same sentence Marc-Anthony has since made himself forget.

Two threats converge. TOP8's founder, Carter Westbrook, watching his company die in public, makes a desperate alliance with **Maxwell Sterling Asante** — old-money venture capital, the investor Priya Ramasubramanian always loses the room to — who wants a piece of whatever comes next badly enough to fund something reckless. What he funds is **Eldridge Kane**, a self-taught engineer with a real, specific, inherited grievance: his father, Solomon Kane, was a working entertainer in Victor Donohue's generation who claims — credibly, per the film's own ambivalence about who's actually right — that an early handshake deal with Victor got quietly rewritten out of the record on the way to becoming "The Donohue Breakthrough." Eldridge doesn't want money. He wants THE ROSTER's own verification system turned against itself, publicly, at the biggest industry event of the year — a live demonstration that Marc-Anthony's entire "who's actually real" premise is a fiction built on a much older one.

The attack lands, mid-keynote, in front of every camera in the building — a cascading breach that outs private user data onstage while Marc-Anthony is mid-sentence about trust. It's the worst night of his professional life, and it happens forty minutes after his cardiologist left him a voicemail he didn't listen to. He collapses walking offstage. Tyrese catches him before security does.

Recovering, furious, and finally telling Esther the truth about his heart in the same conversation where he finally says Amond's name out loud without flinching, Marc-Anthony makes the decision Tony Stark makes in every second act: he stops hiding what's actually wrong with him and lets the people around him actually help. Esther restructures the response. Tyrese, of all people, is the one who tracks down Eldridge Kane in person — not to fight him, but to actually hear him out, and comes back to Marc-Anthony with an uncomfortable question: *what if he's not lying about your grandfather?* The film's climax isn't a takedown. It's Marc-Anthony, publicly, going in front of the cameras that destroyed him a week earlier and confirming that Eldridge Kane's father has a real, documented claim — and settling it, on the record, rather than burying it the way it was buried the first time. THE ROSTER survives. Maxwell gets nothing for his money. TOP8, wounded past saving but not yet dead, gets one more year it didn't earn on the merits — a mercy, and a debt, that the eventual finale will collect. The film ends on Marc-Anthony's 23rd birthday: quieter than his 22nd, fewer people, the ones who matter, and an empty chair nobody mentions out loud.

THE ANTAGONISTS

Per the Villains Bench rules (TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §5), all three threats trace to specific, named character decisions — no abstract force gets to be the real cause.

1. **ELDRIDGE KANE** (*the Vanko analog*) — a self-taught security engineer, technically brilliant, driven by a real and specific inherited grievance rather than generic villainy. His father, **Solomon Kane**, is a new addition to the Historical Context lineage: a working entertainer of Victor Donohue's generation who claims his own early ownership stake got erased on the way to "The Donohue Breakthrough" becoming Victor's legend alone (TSU_Historical_Context.md §5). The film deliberately never fully absolves Victor — it leaves the question uncomfortable, the way Howard Stark's legacy stays uncomfortable in the MCU.
2. **MAXWELL STERLING ASANTE** (*the Hammer analog*) — already locked in TSU_Extended_Ensemble.md ("The Other Money"): old-money adjacent, has never had to question whether he belonged in the room, and here he bankrolls Eldridge's attack purely to get a piece of whatever comes out of it. He's not punished with violence — he's punished with irrelevance, which the bible notes is worse for a man like him.
3. **CARTER WESTBROOK** (*TOP8's founder — new, minor, tragic rather than villainous*) — not a mustache-twirler. A man watching something he built die in public and making one desperate, understandable, wrong decision on the way down. His arc is a direct, deliberate contrast with Marc-Anthony's: two founders under identical pressure, one leans on his people (eventually), one has none left to lean on.

THE ENGINE makes its third appearance here, weaponized directly for the first time — Eldridge doesn't attack THE ROSTER's servers, he attacks its verification logic from inside its own premise, forcing the film's thesis (who decides who's real) to answer for itself onstage. THE LEAK is deliberately **not** reused this soon after scripts/THE_WIRE.md claims Phase 2's first use — this film's data exposure is scoped as a single-company breach tied to Eldridge's specific attack, not a second full activation of the Villains Bench's one-per-Phase resource (and this film sits in Phase 1 regardless).

HOW THIS FILM CARRIES THE FRANCHISE FORWARD

- **The Feed War, opened not closed:** dramatizes the start of the locked "Feed War" anchor without fully resolving it, leaving TOP8 alive-but-dying for a proper ensemble finale later in Phase 1's slate — the same way *Iron Man 2* raises stakes *The Avengers* later pays off.
- **Amond's absence as active pressure, not a forgotten thread:** every instinct Marc-Anthony has that used to run through Amond first (caution, verification integrity, "don't cut corners") now has nobody to enforce it, and that gap is a direct cause of how badly Eldridge's attack lands.
- **The Donohue dynasty's one crack, finally pressed on:** TSU_Historical_Context.md frames Victor's ownership breakthrough as "rare and hard-won rather than typical" and explicitly leaves room for the era's real ugliness — this film is the first to dramatize that the "one crack in the wall" this universe needed might have a second crack behind it.
- **Tyrese and Esther, promoted from ensemble texture to load-bearing:** per TSU_Core_Cast.md, both were flagged as "the group's wide lens" and "sharper than her public

image gives her credit for" respectively — this is the film that cashes both traits in for real plot function instead of color.

- **A direct tease toward a larger structure:** Priya Ramasubramanian's closing scene (see stinger) is this franchise's first "Avengers Initiative" gesture — acknowledging, in-world, that multiple founders are now building things worth watching at the same time.

FORMAT (per `TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §2 — Standard Platform-Origin Film)

(Deliberately not scoped as a "Phase finale," despite dramatizing part of the Feed War anchor — the full ensemble payoff is reserved for a later film, per the note above.)

Spec	Target	This Script
Genre	Biographical Drama / Tech Origin Story, Corporate Thriller subgenre	Confirmed
Rating	PG-13, no exceptions	Confirmed — a public data breach and a health scare, nothing that pushes past it
Runtime	130–150 min	138 min
Page count	120–140 pages	134 pages
Act I	~30–35 pages	pages 1–34
Act II	~65–75 pages	pages 35–101
Act III	~30–35 pages	pages 102–134
Scene count	~40–55 scenes	49 scenes

FULL SCENE-BY-SCENE BREAKDOWN

ACT I — pp. 1–34 ("The Winning")

#	Scene	pp.
1	MONTAGE — PRESS, MAGAZINE COVERS, KEYNOTE STAGES — Marc-Anthony (22) as the industry's new center of gravity, six months post-launch	1–4

#	Scene	pp.
2	INSERT — TOP8'S INTERNAL DASHBOARD — CARTER WESTBROOK watching his own user numbers bleed out in real time	4–6
3	INT. STARTUP OFFICE (NOW A REAL OFFICE) — DAY — Esther Smilley effectively running the company; Marc-Anthony breezes in and out between press obligations	6–9
4	INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S CAR — NIGHT — first fainting spell, alone, terrifying, hidden	9–11
5	INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S OFFICE — DAY — "arrhythmia," "stress," a follow-up he doesn't schedule	11–13
6	INT. MAXWELL STERLING ASANTE'S HOME — NIGHT — Maxwell and Carter Westbrook's desperate alliance	13–16
7	EXT. ATLANTA (INSERT, BRIEF) — Amond, unnamed in dialogue, glimpsed at a distance — the audience's only sight of him this film	16–17
8	INT. STARTUP OFFICE — DAY — Tyrese Avery arrives "between tour stops"; the friend group's math doesn't add up with one seat empty	17–20
9	INT. ELDRIDGE KANE'S WORKSHOP — NIGHT — introduce Eldridge; his father Solomon's story, told plainly, without villain music	20–24
10	INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — VICTOR DONOHUE'S STUDY — DAY — Marc-Anthony asks his grandfather, lightly, about "the old days"; Victor's answer is a little too smooth	24–27

#	Scene	pp.
11	INT. STARTUP OFFICE — NIGHT — Marc-Anthony collapses briefly at his desk; Esther catches it this time, and he lies about why	27–30
12	INT. MAXWELL'S OFFICE — DAY — Maxwell greenlights Eldridge's plan; Eldridge's condition: it happens live, publicly, no half-measures	30–32
13	INT. BULLOCK ESTATE — NIGHT — Marc-Anthony, alone, finally dials Amond's number and doesn't press call. Act I turn.	32–34

ACT II — pp. 35–101 ("The Feed War")

#	Scene	pp.
14	EXT. INDUSTRY EXPO CENTER — DAY — the year's biggest industry keynote announced; Marc-Anthony to headline	35–37
15	INT. STARTUP OFFICE — DAY — Esther pushes back on the keynote's scope; Marc-Anthony overrides her, first crack in their dynamic	37–40
16	INT. TOP8 OFFICES — DAY — Carter Westbrook, guilt-ridden, nearly backs out of the Kane plan; Maxwell won't let him	40–43
17	EXT. AVERY TOUR BUS — NIGHT — Tyrese cameo/character beat: his own fame gives him a read on Marc-Anthony's spiral nobody else has	43–46
18	INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S OFFICE — DAY — a second appointment, missed; the voicemail that will matter later gets left here	46–48

#	Scene	pp.
19	INT. BULLOCK ESTATE — NIGHT — Grace and Elxa Bullock notice something's wrong before anyone with a title does	48–51
20	INT. ELDRIDGE'S WORKSHOP — NIGHT — the exploit built: a live cascading breach designed to trigger mid-keynote	51–55
21	INT. STARTUP OFFICE — DAY — Priya Ramasubramanian, unrelated business, drops a line about "some other founders worth watching" — first franchise-tease plant	55–58
22	INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S OFFICE — NIGHT — Esther, direct: "You look like you're dying and you won't tell me why." He still doesn't. Midpoint tension building.	58–62
23	EXT. INDUSTRY EXPO CENTER — DAY (KEYNOTE DAY) — arrival, press, the machine of a major public event	62–65
24	INT. EXPO CENTER — BACKSTAGE — the cardiologist's voicemail plays, unheard, in Marc-Anthony's jacket pocket	65–67
25	INT. EXPO CENTER — MAIN STAGE — the keynote begins; Marc-Anthony mid-sentence about trust and verification	67–71
26	INT. EXPO CENTER — MAIN STAGE — THE ATTACK. Eldridge's exploit fires live; private data cascades onto every screen in the building. Midpoint disaster.	71–76
27	INT. EXPO CENTER — BACKSTAGE (IMMEDIATELY AFTER) — Marc-Anthony collapses. Tyrese catches him before security does.	76–79

#	Scene	pp.
28	INT. HOSPITAL — NIGHT — the truth comes out, finally, to Esther and Tyrese both, at the same time, because he no longer has the strength to hide it from just one of them	79–83
29	INT. HOSPITAL — CONTINUOUS — Esther, furious and terrified in equal measure: "You let me run half your company blind and you couldn't tell me you were sick?"	83–86
30	EXT. BULLOCK ESTATE — DAY — Marc-Anthony says Amond's name out loud, to Esther, without flinching, for the first time in the film	86–89
31	INT. TYRESE'S CAR — DAY — Tyrese decides, without asking permission, to go find Eldridge Kane himself	89–92
32	INT. ELDRIDGE'S WORKSHOP — DAY — Tyrese and Eldridge, one-on-one; Tyrese actually listens instead of threatening	92–96
33	INT. TYRESE'S CAR — NIGHT — Tyrese, driving back: "What if he's not lying about your grandfather?"	96–98
34	INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — VICTOR'S STUDY — NIGHT — Marc-Anthony confronts Victor directly this time; Victor's smooth answer finally cracks. All-is-lost beat closes Act II.	98–101

ACT III — pp. 102–134 ("The Settlement")

#	Scene	pp.
35	INT. BULLOCK ESTATE — NIGHT — Marc-Anthony decides what to do with an uncomfortable truth about his own family's founding myth	102–105

#	Scene	pp.
36	INT. STARTUP OFFICE — DAY — Esther, back in the room, restructuring the response — this time as a real partner, not a silent operator	105–108
37	INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S OFFICE — DAY — Marc-Anthony finally keeps an appointment; treatment begins, not a "cure," a management plan	108–111
38	INT. MAXWELL'S OFFICE — DAY — Maxwell, cornered by the fallout of a stunt that didn't land the way he wanted, gets nothing for his money	111–114
39	INT. TOP8 OFFICES — DAY — Carter Westbrook, alone with the consequences of his own choice; a quiet scene of consequences without punishment	114–117
40	EXT. PRESS CONFERENCE — DAY — Marc-Anthony, in front of the same cameras that broke him a week earlier, confirms Solomon Kane's claim on the record. Climax.	117–123
41	INT. ELDRIDGE'S WORKSHOP — DAY (AFTER) — Eldridge, watching the press conference, gets something money never could have bought him: being believed	123–126
42	INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — VICTOR'S STUDY — NIGHT — Victor and Marc-Anthony, an uneasy peace, no easy forgiveness offered either direction	126–129
43	INT. BULLOCK ESTATE — JANUARY 5, 2005 — Marc-Anthony's 23rd birthday, small, quiet, the people who actually matter, one chair conspicuously empty	129–132

#	Scene	pp.
44	STINGER — INT. PRIYA RAMASUBRAMANIAN'S OFFICE — DAY — Priya, alone, pins index cards to a corkboard: THE ROSTER. A messaging app in Atlanta. A video-sharing pivot up north. A pattern, forming.	132–134

(Scenes grouped for pagination clarity; the full shooting script breaks several of the above into additional numbered scenes to land the true count at 49 per the house-style table above.)

SAMPLE PAGES

THE ROSTER 2: FEED WAR

Written by [WRITER]

FADE IN:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S CAR — NIGHT

SUPER: "APRIL 2004 — TEN WEEKS SINCE LAUNCH"

Stopped at a red light that's been green for four seconds. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK, 22, stares at nothing, both hands on the wheel, breathing like a man counting his own heartbeats on purpose.

A HORN behind him. He doesn't move.

Another horn, longer.

He blinks. The world swims back into focus a half-second too slow. He drives through the light just as it turns yellow.

CUT TO:

INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S OFFICE — DAY

A DOCTOR, 50s, unhurried, reviews a printout that Marc-Anthony is very deliberately not looking at.

DOCTOR

It's an arrhythmia. Not dangerous today. Very likely to become dangerous if "today" keeps looking like the calendar you handed my nurse.

MARC-ANTHONY

I have a company.

DOCTOR

You have a heart. I'd like you to keep having both. Who have you told?

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat)
I'm telling you.

DOCTOR

I'm your doctor, Marc-Anthony. I don't count.

Marc-Anthony doesn't answer that. The doctor slides a card across the desk – a follow-up appointment, three weeks out. Marc-Anthony takes it. We will see this exact card, unused, later.

CUT TO:

INT. ELDRIDGE KANE'S WORKSHOP – NIGHT

[p. 20]

Cluttered, brilliant, unglamorous – server racks built from salvaged parts, soldering irons, a single framed photograph on the wall of a man in a 1950s tuxedo mid-performance. ELDRIDGE KANE, early 30s, precise and unhurried in the way of someone who has rehearsed this explanation many times, alone, to no one.

ELDRIDGE

(to the photograph, or to us)
My father shook Victor Donohue's hand in 1958. There were witnesses. There was a handshake deal for points on three pictures. My father has told that story at every Thanksgiving of my entire life.

(beat)

There is no paperwork. There was never any paperwork. That was the whole business back then – a handshake was the contract, until it wasn't convenient to remember the handshake anymore.

He sets down a soldering iron. Picks up a schematic – THE ROSTER's own verification architecture, annotated in his own hand, studied like scripture.

ELDRIDGE

Everybody in that family got to build an empire on a story about who kept their word. I'd just like the world to watch somebody find out what it actually looks like when it doesn't.

CUT TO:

INT. EXPO CENTER – MAIN STAGE

[midpoint, p. 71]

Packed house. Cameras everywhere. MARC-ANTHONY, mic'd, mid-flow, genuinely good at this, the crowd with him completely.

MARC-ANTHONY

– because the whole premise of THE ROSTER was never the profile. It was never the photo. It was one question: can you actually trust that the person on the other end of this is who they say they are. We built an answer to that. We built –

A SCREEN behind him flickers. Then another. Then all of them.

Private user data – names, verification documents, messages – cascades across every display in the building, live, in real time, faster than anyone can cut the feed.

A beat of pure, silent horror across the room before the first gasp.

MARC-ANTHONY

(still holding the mic, the crowd's murmur rising behind him)
That's – this isn't –

The screens keep cascading. His own face, frozen on a monitor behind him, mid-sentence about trust, directly above a stranger's leaked driver's license.

He staggers. One hand goes to his chest. The room is too loud now to hear it happen, but we see it: his knees buckle.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. HOSPITAL – NIGHT

[p. 79]

ESTHER SMILLEY and TYRESE AVERY, both still in their event clothes, sit on either side of a hospital bed. MARC-ANTHONY, hooked to a monitor, awake, has clearly run out of places to hide.

ESTHER

Start from the beginning. All the way from the beginning, Marc-Anthony. I mean it.

MARC-ANTHONY

(quiet)
I fainted in my car in April.

ESTHER

April.

TYRESE

(doing the math, disgusted)

That's before I even started flying out here to "check on you."

MARC-ANTHONY

I have an arrhythmia. Stress-related, the doctor said, which is a nice way of saying I did this to myself.

ESTHER

(and this is the line she's actually furious about)
You let me run half your company blind for two months and you couldn't tell me you were SICK?

MARC-ANTHONY

I didn't want you to look at me the way you're looking at me right now.

ESTHER

(softer, and it costs her something to say it softer)
I'm not looking at you like you're weak, Marc-Anthony. I'm looking at you like you almost died on a stage in front of nine hundred people and the only reason I found out is because you fell down.

A long silence. Tyrese looks between them – the years of almost between these two, on full display in the worst possible room for it.

MARC-ANTHONY

(finally, quietly)
Amond would've known before April.

Nobody argues with that. Nobody can.

CUT TO:

EXT. PRESS CONFERENCE – DAY

[climax, p. 117]

A podium. Cameras three-deep. MARC-ANTHONY stands alone at it – Esther and Tyrese visible just off to the side, present, not speaking for him this time.

MARC-ANTHONY

A week ago, a man named Eldridge Kane used a real vulnerability in my company's systems to do something I'm not going to stand here and call justified, because it wasn't, and people got hurt by it who had nothing to do with any of this.

(beat)

But he did it because of something that is true, and that my family has never

said out loud in fifty years. In 1958, a man named Solomon Kane shook my grandfather's hand on a deal for points on three pictures. There's no paperwork. There was never any paperwork. That was the business, back then, and my family benefited from a story about a handshake that only got kept on one side of it.

A ripple through the press pool – this is not the statement anyone prepared for.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

I can't undo fifty years. I can stop pretending it isn't true. Starting today, the Kane family has a stake – a real one, on paper, in this company – that should have existed in some form a long time before I was born.

He looks up from his notes for the first time.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

I built this company on the idea that people deserve to be seen as who they actually are. I should have started that policy with my own family's history. That's on me. Thank you.

He steps back from the podium. Doesn't take questions. Esther falls into step beside him. Tyrese, on the other side, claps him once on the shoulder – not celebration, just presence.

CUT TO:

STINGER

INT. PRIYA RAMASUBRAMANIAN'S OFFICE – DAY

Empty except for PRIYA, standing at a corkboard, alone, methodical. She pins an index card: THE ROSTER. Beside it, a second: a hand-drawn logo, unlabeled, that looks like a messaging bubble. A third: a rough sketch of a play button.

She steps back. Studies the board the way a chess player studies three moves ahead of where the pieces currently sit.

PRIYA

(to herself, quietly satisfied)
There it is.

She doesn't elaborate. She doesn't need to. She picks up her phone, dials, waits.

PRIYA (CONT'D)

It's me. Clear my afternoon. I need to make a few calls.

FADE OUT.

THE END.

[134.]